Yifan ZHANG

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Current Position

Postdoctoral Fellow, Kellogg School of Management, Northwestern University, 2025 - present
Supervisor: Nancy Qian

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, Toulouse School of Economics, 2025
Thesis: Essays on Economic History and Political Economy
Advisors: Victor Gay, Paul Seabright, Mohamed Saleh (first two years)

Visiting student, Department of Economics, Northwestern University, April-July 2024
Host: Joel Mokyr

M.A. in Economic Theory and Econometrics, Toulouse School of Economics, 2020

B.B.A. in Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen, 2018

Research Fields

Primary: Development Economics, Political Economy, Economic History

Secondary: Culture and Institutions, Gender, Media

Job Market Paper

The Transmission of Son Preference

Abstract: This paper examines how culturally rooted son preference contributes to missing women. I exploit the quasi-random settlement of mainland Chinese migrants in Taiwan and measure their cultural backgrounds using ancestor worship in their places of origin. Local families exposed to migrants from origins with stronger ancestor worship are more likely to continue childbearing without a son and, after the Legalization of Abortion in 1985, to select sons at higher birth orders. Among second-generation migrants, sex selection is associated not only with the ancestor worship of their fathers' places of origin but also with those of other migrant groups in their communities. The evidence shows how a preference for sons is sustained across generations and spreads beyond the families that pass it down, contributing to missing women.

Working Papers

Media Exposure and Occupational Choice with Mingduo Zhao (University of British Columbia)

The Economic Determinants of Taiwanese Sentiments towards Reunification with Mainland China with Yu-Chi Hsieh (Northwestern), Nancy Qian (Northwestern), and Marco Tabellini (Harvard)

References

Nancy Qian
James J. O'Connor Professor
Northwestern University
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Victor Gay
Professor of Economics
Toulouse School of Economics
victor.gay@tse-fr.eu

Paul Seabright
Professor of Economics
Toulouse School of Economics
paul.seabright@tse-fr.eu

Marco E. Tabellini
Assistant Professor of Business Administration
Harvard University
mtabellini@hbs.edu

Seminars & Conferences

2027 ASSA (Washington DC, scheduled)

2026 National Taiwan University (x2), Economic History Association Meeting (St. Louis), Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China (Hong Kong),

2025 Institutional and Organizational Economics Academy (Corsica), Northwestern University (x2), Toulouse School of Economics

2024 ASREC Annual Conference (Chapman University), Annual Symposium on Quantitative History (Shanghai), Cliometric Annual Conference (Washington DC), Econometric Society European Meeting (Rotterdam), Economic History Society Annual Conference (Newcastle), Stockholm School of Economics, London School of Economics, Northwestern University, Toulouse School of Economics

2021-2023 Quantitative History Workshop (Shanghai), ENTER Jamboree (Manheim), Toulouse School of Economics (x5), ENTER Jamboree webinar (virtual discussant)

Grants & Awards

Postdoc Conference Travel Grant, Northwestern University	2026
Final Year Fellowship, Toulouse School of Economics	2024-2025
Conference Bursary, Economic History Society	2024
Mobility Grant (7,180 EUR), Toulouse School of Economics	2024
Doctoral Fellowship, French Ministry of Education	2021-2024
First-year Ph.D. Student Fellowship, Toulouse School of Economics	2020
The Galaxy World Student Entrepreneur Fund (80,000 CNY)	2015
Half Tuition Scholarship (190,000 CNY), The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen	2014-2018

Research Experience

Research assistant to Victor Gay (Toulouse School of Economics)	2024-2025
Research assistant to Zhuang (John) Liu (The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen)	2016-2018

Teaching Experience

Teaching assistant for Program Evaluation (Graduate), TSE. Instructor: Thierry Magnac, Spring 2023

Teaching assistant for Microeconomics (Undergraduate), TSE. Instructor: Lucie Bottega, Spring 2024

Teaching assistant for Macroeconomics (Undergraduate), TSE. Instructor: Patrick Fève, Fall 2023

Teaching assistant for Industrial Organization (Undergraduate), TSE. Instructor: Isabelle Dubec, Spring 2022

Referee Service

Economics of Transition and Institutional Change

Professional Service

China Econ Lab, *Social Media Coordinator* 2025 - present

Economic History Society, *Student Ambassador* 2022-2025

The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen, *Alumni Advisor* 2022-2023

Others

Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native), Cantonese (fluent), English (fluent), French (basic)

IT skills: ArcGIS, Matlab, Python, R, Stata

Last updated: October 21, 2026